

Handouts 02

CULTURE

- Culture is people's way of life. It is their pattern of behavior, which has been created by human beings.
- Culture is manmade part of the society
- Culture is shared way of life which is transmitted from one generation to another with the accumulation of individual experiences.
- Culture encompasses language, beliefs system, values, norms, behaviors, and even material objects that characterize a group and are passed from one generation to the next.

Definition of Culture

Following are some important definitions of culture by sociologists

Horton and Hunt definition of culture, "Culture is everything which is socially shared and learned by the members of a society."

Tylor defined "Culture is that complex whole which include knowledge, belief, art, morals, law, custom, and any other capabilities and habits acquired by man as a member of society."

It is the totality of human experience acquired during transmission of heritage from one generation to another and to learn the ways of learning, eating, drinking, behaving, walking, dressing, and working is the culture of man.

Types of Culture

Material culture (tangible culture) Physical objects created by man. These objects that are created by members of the culture, such as art, buildings, weapons, utensils, machines, hairstyles, food, and jewelry dresses etc.

Non-material culture (intangible culture) A group's ways of thinking (including social norms, beliefs, values, and other assumptions about the world) and doing (its common patterns of behavior, including language and other forms of interaction). It is also called intangible culture.

Features/Characteristics of Cultures

Culture is

- **Universal**
- **learned**
- **shared**
- **transmitted**
- **Changing.**

Culture is universal:

- **Universality:** Culture is universal. There is no society without culture. As part of the cultures there are many aspects that are found in almost all the societies.
- For example the institutions like marriage and family, religion, education, polity, economy, and sports are found all over the world.
- All the societies have developed values, norms, beliefs, and other patterns of behavior that govern the system of marriage and family. One could find such a pattern all over the world, and the same is applicable to religion, education, political behavior, economic behavior, and so on.

Culture has variability

- There is variability in the culture. Every society has a culture of its own. It differs from society to society. Culture of every society is unique in itself. Cultures are not uniform.
 - Ways of eating, speaking, greeting, dressing, entertaining, living etc. of different groups of people differ significantly.
 - Marriage patterns e.g. arranged marriages, love marriages, exchange marriages, marriages by purchase, marriages within as well as outside the kin network, these all are the variations that are found in different cultures of Pakistan. Then one could see the differences in wedding ceremonies all over the country.
 - Religion: Similarly one can observe difference/ variations in religion all over the world.
 - Governments system: Kingship, dictatorship, democracy, parliamentary form of democracy or presidential form, adult franchise or selective voting rights, voter age are all variations in the political systems followed by different nations.
 - Economic systems may also vary from society to society such as socialism and capitalism.

Culture is learned

- Culture is learned through the process of interaction with others. It is not inherited through the biological process. Culture is not biological programming rather it is social programming.
- It is not an inborn tendency but acquired by man from the association with others, e.g.
- We learn to talk, to walk, and to act from our elders. Human beings have the capacity to learn a variety of languages. Similarly other ways of life, which is culture, are learned.

- Drinking
- Eating
- Dressing
- Walking
- Behaving

Culture is shared

- Shared: Culture is not the property of one individual or of a group.
- Culture is something that is shared. It is nothing that an individual can pass but shared by common people of a territory.
- For example, customs, traditions, values, beliefs are all shared by man in a social situation. These beliefs and practices are adopted by all equally.
- Human beings share culture to maintain integrity and to predict others' behaviors and acts in a certain situation.

Culture is transmitted

- Culture is transmitted from one generation to the other.
- It is not transmitted through genes but through interaction. People transmit culture through communication and language is considered a means of communication which passes cultural traits from one generation to another.
- During its lifetime that individual or group tries to pass on its culture to the future generation. This is how every new crop of babies does not start from a scratch rather they build on what they have already received. That is how culture grows and that is how our culture becomes richer and richer.

Culture is changing

- Culture is continuously changing. The patterns of behavior transmitted by one generation to another are continuously in the process of modification for catering to the changing needs of time and demands of people.

– New technologies are developed and are borrowed from other groups and societies.

With the increase in the contact between different societies the cultures are changing very fast and may be moving toward some kind of global culture.

Elements of Culture

Elements/Components of Culture

Following are the main elements of the culture. These elements may look different across cultures, and many change with time as a society evolves.

- **language**
- **Symbols**
- **Norms**
- **Sanctions**
- **values,**
- **Belief System**
- **Rituals/ Ceremonies/ Festivals**

Artifacts

1. Language

Language is a set of symbols. It is source of communication and transmission of culture from one generation to another. Each culture has its own language but human beings have ability to learn others culture's language when they come in a situation of interaction.

- Language is a system of words and symbols used to communicate with other people..
- The primary way in which people communicate with one another is through language and to transmit message from one person to another.
- Language is a set of socially sound pattern, words, and sentences having specific meaning and terminology common to the same culture.
- Language differs from culture to culture and is transmitted from one generation to another.
- English, Spanish, French, Urdu, Punjabi, Hindi etc. But, it also includes body language, slang, and common phrases that are unique to certain groups of people.

2. Symbols:

Anything that carries a particular meaning recognized by people who share that culture.

- A symbol consists of gestures (such as smile, feet touching, bow down, hand shake) and objects (such as flags, turban etc).
- A symbol is something to which people attach meaning and that they use to communicate with one another such as
 - Whistle,
 - Thumbs up.
 - Red Light
 - Business Logos

Symbols often evoke various reactions and emotions.

For example the heap of ash show that the something has been burnt or the wet street shows that it has rained.

Bowing head, whistling, winking of eyes situation, all are the symbols, which express a specific object idea about other. Bait Ullah is the symbol of God and we pray to it. American Shake their hand to answer for No. Other examples are flag, anthem, picture, statues are symbols.

Symbols are the short expression for the identification of an object or situation. People learn symbols while observing other people of same culture.

Human beings have the capacity to create symbols with different meanings associated with each. These symbols are used as means of communication and thereby become part of our language.

3. Social Norms:

Norms are the rules and regulations which specify the behavior of an individual.

These are the expectations of society for “right” behavior. Norms explain what people do and what not to do in a certain situation.

- "Norms refer to shared rules about acceptable and unacceptable social behavior“

Norms keep a person within the boundary of society and its culture. It molds our behavior and help to make it acceptable and appropriate.

Types of Norms:

- ❖ **Informal Norms (Folkways, Customs)**
- ❖ **Formal Norms (Mores, Taboos, Laws)**
- ❖ **Folkways:**

Folkways are the simple customary ways of the people that are related to daily life routine. It is the normal and habitual action of people within a culture. Folkways are the recognized or accepted

ways of behavior. These are the behavior pattern which a person use generally in his daily life. Folkways norms are not strictly enforced.

R.T. Schaefer has defined it as: “Folk ways are norms governing everyday behavior where violation raises comparatively little concern.”

- Examples: Folkways are the rules of eating, drinking, meeting and departing, types of dressing, ceremonies and rituals for different situations, and the manners of life in institutional situations as family, school, market and mosque.
- If violates, people criticize the violator by joking, laughing at, advising and taunting, making fun, silly, and no sense.

❖ Customs

A custom (also called a tradition) is a common way of doing things. It is something that many people do, and have done for a long time. Usually, the people come from the same country, culture, or religion.

- Examples: Shaking hands, bowing, Dowry etc.

❖ Mores:

THAT type of Norms that are the standards of morality that are set by society for individuals. These are strictly enforced because they are thought essential to core moral values and considered essential for the wellbeing of the group.

The term mores refers to the norms set by society, largely for behavior and appearance.

Individuals who do not follow social mores are often considered social deviants.

Examples

- Permission before entering in friend’s home,
- respect for Quran, mosque, church ,

- Eating halal meat, politeness, etc.

❖ **Taboos**

- Taboo is something that's prohibited for religious or social reasons.
- A taboo refers to a norm so strongly ingrained that even the thought of its violation is greeted with revulsion. When someone breaks a taboo, the individual is usually judged unfit to live in the same society as others. The sanctions are severe and may include prison, banishment, or death.
 - Eating human flesh.
 - Abortion - terminating a pregnancy
 - Adultery - sexual intercourse with someone other than your spouse
 - Intermarriage - marriage between people who are closely related
 - Offensive language - obscenity or vulgarity
 - Halaal - Islamic rules of eating include not eating the meat of omnivores or carnivores and not drinking alcohol
 - Religious vegetarianism - some religions prohibit the eating of meat and fish

❖ **Laws**

Laws are that type of norms which are formed and implemented by a political entity e.g. traffic laws, civil laws and tax laws etc.

4. Sanctions

Sanctions are the negative and positive reactions to ensure the implementation of social norms.

Without sanctions it's almost impossible to ensure norms.

Positive sanctions include smile, appreciation, prize, gifts etc.

Negative sanction include fine, punishment, imprisonment, rebuke, criticism etc.

5. Values:

Values the general guidelines/principles that guide you to decide what is right and what is wrong.

These are standards by which people define what is desirable or undesirable, good or bad, beautiful

A culture's values are its ideas about what is good, right, fair, and just.

- In simple words, values may be defined as measure of goodness or desirability.
- Values such as fundamental rights, patriotism, respect for human dignity, kindness, honesty, truthfulness, rationality, sacrifice, individuality, equality, democracy etc.. Values are the criteria people use in assessing their daily lives; arrange their priorities and choosing between alternative courses of action.

Anything getting importance in our daily life becomes our values. The origin of values is not biological but it is social production while living in society the values develop. Values depend upon the culture. Culture varies from society to society and thus values are different in every social situation.

6. Belief System

Beliefs are the specific thoughts or ideas that people consider to be true. The beliefs fulfill peoples spirituals needs. Every culture has firm faith in religion. There are different religions in the world such as Islam, Christianity and Hinduism and Judaism etc. followers of each religions follow its laws. Despite beliefs every culture has myth system which are widely held but false ideas.

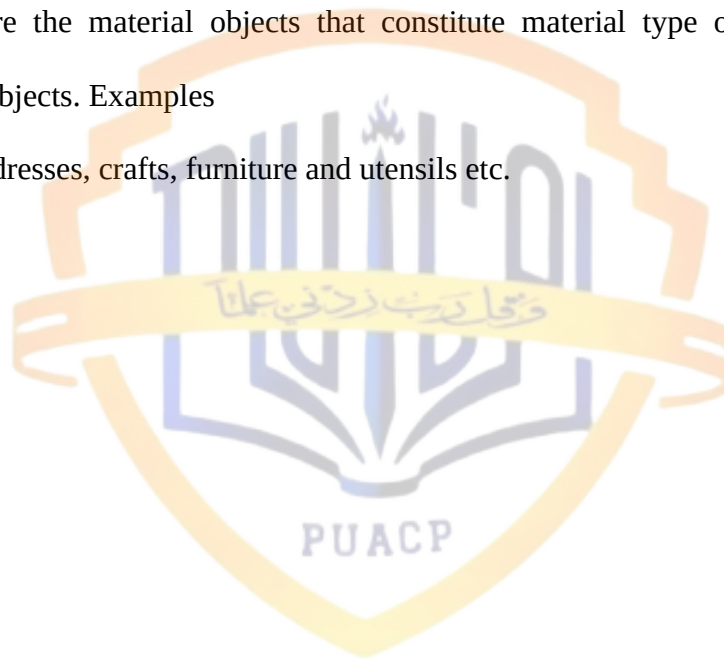
7. Rituals/ceremonies/festivals

Every culture has its rituals which are the religious acts that are performed collectively and establish sense of unity such as different acts performed during Haj in Islam. Despite rituals every culture has its own ceremonies and festivals such as *Eid ul Fitar* and *Eid ul Adha* in Islam, christmas in Christianity or *Deewali* in Hinduism. These festivals are performed for as recreational activities. Some other cultural days and festivals are celebrate which may vary from culture to culture.

8. Artifacts

Artifacts are the material objects that constitute material type of culture. These are manmade objects. Examples

Buildings, dresses, crafts, furniture and utensils etc.



Cultural Diversity

The term cultural diversity is often used interchangeably with the concept of “multiculturalism”, which may be defined as existence of different cultures along with the dominant culture within the same geographical area. The cultural diversity meaning is an ideological belief upheld in societies that recognize, appreciate, and respect the cultural behaviors and presence of other people or people from diversified groups.

Dr. Caleb Rosado has defined the term cultural diversity as: “a system of beliefs and behaviors that recognizes and respects the presence of all diverse groups in mainstream culture, acknowledges and values their socio-cultural differences, encourages and enables their continued contribution within an inclusive cultural context which empowers all within the organization or society.

Characteristics of Cultural Diversity:

Keeping in view the above given definition of cultural diversity, we can elaborate seven important characteristics of cultural diversity.

- **Recognition** of the abundant diversity of culture around;
- **Respect** for the differences/ difference in the practices or traits;
- **Acknowledging** the validity of contribution of different cultural groups
- **Valuing** what other cultures offer for the overall development of the society;
- **Encouraging** the contribution of diverse groups for socio-economic development;
- **Empowering** people to strengthen themselves and others to achieve their maximum potential by being critical of their own biases;
- **Celebrating** rather than just tolerating the differences in order to bring about unity through diversity.

Measures/Steps to Secure Cultural Diversity

- For meaningful relationship increase your level of understanding about other cultures by interacting with people outside of your own culture.
- Avoid imposing values on others that may cause conflict.
- When interacting with others who may not be proficient in English, recognize that their limitations in English proficiency in no way reflects their level of intellectual functioning.
- Recognize and understand that concepts within the helping profession, such as family, gender roles, spirituality, and emotional well-being, vary significantly among cultures and influence behavior.
- Within the workplace, educational setting, and/or clinical setting, advocate for the use of materials that are representative of the various cultural groups.
- Intervene in an appropriate manner when you observe others engaging in behaviors that show cultural biasness and prejudice.
- Be proactive in listening, accepting, and welcoming people and ideas that are different from your own.

Benefits of Cultural Diversity/importance of Cultural Diversity

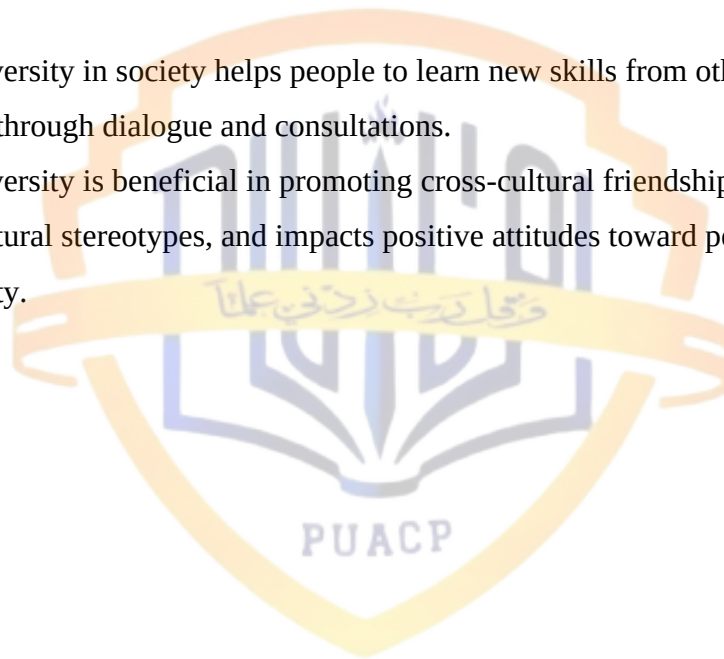
Cultural diversity is important because our country, workplaces, and schools increasingly consist of various cultural, racial, and ethnic groups. We can learn from one another, but first we must have a level of understanding about each other in order to facilitate collaboration and cooperation. Learning about other cultures helps us understand different perspectives within the world in which we live, and helps dispel negative stereotypes and personal biases about different groups.

In addition, cultural diversity helps us recognize and respect “ways of being” that are not necessarily our own, so that as we interact with others we can build bridges to trust, respect, and understanding across cultures. Furthermore, this diversity makes our country a more interesting

place to live, as people from diverse cultures contribute language skills, new ways of thinking, new knowledge, and different experiences.

In the modern world, there are various benefits associated with cultural diversity. The main key benefits include;

- Cultural diversity leads towards innovation of ideas and thinking.
- It helps promote peaceful coexistence among people from different cultures in their workplace, institutions, and social settings.
- Cultural diversity helps promote respect for other people's cultures and learn how they act and live.
- Cultural diversity in society helps people to learn new skills from others and encourage innovation through dialogue and consultations.
- Cultural diversity is beneficial in promoting cross-cultural friendship, increases comfort, reduces cultural stereotypes, and impacts positive attitudes toward people living in a given society.



Culture related Concepts

Enculturation:

- Enculturation is the process of learning one's own culture, it does not necessarily lead towards any modification in the cultural practices.
- Enculturation is the first learning of an individual or group of people.
- It is a process which every individual have to go through, in the course of his/her life.

Acculturation:

- Acculturation is the process of learning about others cultural practices and traits without losing one's own culture identity.
- It is a process of second culture learning and adopting to new culture with some modifications and adjustments.
- For example people who go abroad for some purpose, so they have to learn that culture for their adjustment in that particular society.

Cultural Assimilation:

- Cultural assimilation is the condition when minority culture blends into a majority/mainstream culture.
- Cultural assimilation process involves adopting the cultural traits and practices of the majority culture to such an extent that one loses its own identity.
- Assimilating groups becomes totally indistinguishable from the people of majority group because they give up practicing their own culture.
- Example maybe the immigrants who live in other cultures for generation or for a long period of time.

Ethnocentrism

- Ethnocentrism is the process of evaluating others cultures practices, traits, values and norms through the standards prevailing in one's own-culture. There is a tendency to judge other cultures, societies, groups, and races from one's own standards.
- Ethnocentrism maybe defined as "a belief that one's own group, race, society and culture is good, normal, right and superior to other groups, culture, society and race that are inferior, wrong, abnormal and bad."
- Ethnocentrism is judging another culture based upon the values and standards set in one's own culture. It is a form of bias, where we tend to immediately judge another culture as

'bad' or 'wrong' based upon their actions, if their values are not aligned with our own beliefs.

Ethnocentrism is the phenomenon in which one use one's own culture as a yardstick for judging the ways of other individuals or societies, generally leading to a negative evaluation of their values, norms, and behaviors.

- Ethnocentrism is the belief that only our culture is the best in every way."

Xenocentrism

- Xenocentrism is the belief that other cultures are the best than those of one's own.
- It is the preference for cultural practices or traits of others cultures.
- Feelings of xenocentrism are usually caused by three factors. (i) Individuals who have familial ties to a foreign country, specifically who have migrated to other cultures and have been living there over a long period of time. (ii) Those who oppose the political choices of their own country, and the third one is (iii) Individuals who are exposed to other cultures and grow dissatisfied with their society, and then rebel against it.

Cultural Relativism

- Cultural relativism is the belief that every culture is equally valid, so you have no right to impose your culture's values on other cultures."
- Cultural relativism not judging a culture with the standards of your own culture rather try to understand it on its own rules and regulations.
- Cultural relativism is the idea that a person's beliefs, values, and practices should be understood based on that person's own culture, rather than judged against the criteria of another.

Cultural shock

- Cultural shock *personal disorientation when experiencing an unfamiliar way of life.*
- Cultural shock is the term we use to describe the feelings of confusion and uncertainty that are experienced when you come into contact with a culture that is vastly different from your own. Culture shock can be commonly seen in foreign students, immigrants and refugees.

Cultural lag

- It refers to the phenomenon that occurs when changes in material culture occur at a faster rate than the changes in non-material culture.
- In other words, cultural lag is when technological advancement occur faster than changes/development in norms, values and the belief system. Let's look at an example to better understand cultural lag.
- According to sociologist [William Ogburn](#), technology has tremendous impact on society and in creating social change; he said that technology changes society by three processes: invention, discovery, and diffusion. The resulting changes of these processes, however, may “lag” behind social changes that result from any of the three processes. In other words, it takes time for us—in terms of the way we go about living—to ‘catch up’ with technology, Ogburn referred to this as cultural lag.

Subculture:

- Subculture is just as it sounds—a smaller cultural group within a larger culture; people of a subculture are part of the larger culture, but also share a specific identity within a smaller group.
- Subculture accepts the dominant culture to some or large extent but stands unique from it by one or more culturally distinct characteristics as well.
- A subculture is a cultural group within a culture that differs in one or more ways from the culture.
- Subculture peacefully coexist with the dominant culture due to common interests and in hand with the dominant culture for the uplift of the society as a whole.

Counterculture:

- Counterculture is a group of people whose culture (social norms, belief system and values) is totally incompatible with the dominant/mainstream culture.
- A counterculture is any group whose views differ significantly from the mainstream culture.
- Due to huge differences in norms and values, such group of people are usually not accepted by the people of dominant culture and vice versa.

- Incompatibility of counterculture make the peaceful coexistence impossible rather it leads to violence.
- Group of counterculture demands radical changes in the existing system wants to impose their ideology, norms, values and customs through demonstration.
- Examples of counterculture include movement of black people in America and feminist movements in patriarchal society.

